

don't make us go "wow." Product after product came out this year only to have us mull ponderously over the spec sheets rather than go "wow." If we saw FM and AM radio on a portable media player, we took it in our stride, and lived our lives.

As of today, when you go looking for a personal media player (PMP), it's pure mix and match. Tick-mark the features you want and there's a product waiting for you. A 100 GB disk device with no screen and with FM radio, which can play back video and record TV and has a remote. Something with a 3.5-inch TFT, which is an MP3 and MP4 player, DVD recorder, e-book reader, and a photo album. Perhaps it's got a camera as well. It's all good.

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be more... one indication is that the Zune could be part of Microsoft's Live Anywhere network. Zune might therefore extend the PMP into the gaming realm. And what is Live Anywhere? Space doesn't permit a full discussion, but Live Anywhere is about accessing online games as well as digital multimedia "anywhere," whether on Xbox 360, Windows Vista, and... probably Zune. You get something called a "gamertag," a set of "achievements," and a "list of friends." These are synced between devices, and one player on an Xbox 360 and the other at a PC can play each other as easily and seamlessly as two players at two Xbox 360s.

Getting all newsy, "Will The iPod Fight Back?" is our question. There's supposedly an iPod with a touch-screen in the works (it's rumoured to be released next year). Apple has been hiring game programmers as well for the iPod, and NVIDIA recently announced it will be supplying video chips for the iPod—so 3D gaming on the iPod may not be far away, either.

Touching upon the Archos 04 series, these are ridiculously-multifunctional do-it-alls. The Archos 604-WiFi gives you Web access via the Opera browser, a touch screen, a widescreen display, audio and video recording, an inbuilt speaker, and can be used as to stream movies and music. Optionally, it can record TV, and it is also IPTV-compatible. And it can be used as a camcorder. Etc., etc., etc.

Those et ceteras define PMP evolution in 2006.



For the zillionth time, we ask: will the Zune kill the iPod?

2006, and with Flash all poised to get bigger like we said, all we can expect is more battery life—the most obvious bottleneck to ultimate portability. Flash apart, too, the batteries are getting better—various i-things from a company called iLuv boost the iPod Video's battery life to something that would have sounded ludicrous last year—50+ hours!

You've heard quite enough about Zune, we presume, and how it'll create wireless communities of music-oriented people. But this is an official year-end report, so we can't leave the Zune out—Microsoft finally got in. As of this writing, the jury's still out on "iPod-killer or still-born." Then someone "attacks the Zune—For Good Reason," in the 2,128,319th such blog post. Why is everyone writing so much? It's just a PMP, and yet, the Internet is still agog with iPod vs. Zune.

Or is it just a PMP? Turns out it's not! Going by the Xbox roots of the gadget, it'll probably

OPTICAL MEDIA

When we spoke about the Blu-ray / HD-DVD war in *The Battle Of The Blue*, in our December 2005 issue, there were several "D"s wanting to come up. We thought China would do something about its EVD (Enhanced Versatile Disc). Somehow, things seem not to have worked out, and it's hardly in the news now. Blu-ray and HD-DVD have, of course, arrived, as expected, on-time. Blu-ray, in fact, has even made it to Indian shores, with the recorder priced in the range of half a lakh.

It's happening because of HD movies, of course, and when you realise what Blu-ray discs will be used for besides backups—about six hours of HD movies on a 50 GB Blu-ray disc—suddenly, the capacity doesn't seem so mammoth any more, and it seems like a virtue has been made of a necessity.

March, Toshiba launched the world's first HD-DVD player in Japan, beating Blu-ray to market, and also the first laptop to feature an HD-DVD drive. April, Toshiba's players hit US store shelves. Later, in May, Sony unveiled a line



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